

The 2026 Standard for Restrained Editorial Motion — and a Squarespace Implementation Map for hausofsparrow.com

TL;DR

- The current premium standard is "motion as pacing, not decoration": subtle image-scale-within-a-crop hovers, wipe-in link underlines, and single-fire fade-up reveals, all timed fast (150–300ms hover, 400–900ms entrance) on ease-out curves — and nearly all of it is achievable on Squarespace with pure Custom CSS. The dominant 2026 vocabulary in Codrops/Awwwards case studies is literally "restraint," "quiet," and "emerge, not appear."
- Recommended tight set (6 surgical additions): (1) a motion-token system (duration + easing variables + a `prefers-reduced-motion` baseline); (2) a wipe-in ink underline on links/nav; (3) image scale-within-`overflow:hidden` on project tiles (~1.045); (4) a single-fire fade-up reveal via IntersectionObserver; (5) `clamp()` fluid type for the display scale; (6) refined nav/button hover via weight/tracking rather than color. Every one is CSS-only except the reveal, which is a ~10-line IntersectionObserver snippet — no library.
- Reject as dated/overwrought: cursor followers/trails, splash intros, video backgrounds, letter-by-letter typewriter reveals, heavy parallax, scroll-jacking, and marquee tickers. Lenis smooth-scroll is still current *only* as light native-scroll smoothing, but it does not serve legibility — defer it. Native CSS scroll-driven animations (`animation-timeline`) are NOT yet production-safe as a sole mechanism (mid-2026 global support ≈82.58%; Firefox only shipped `scroll()` at v155, Safari/iOS at 26).

Key Findings

1. The register has shifted decisively toward restraint. Codrops' 2026 studio case studies frame the goal as removal, not addition. The Podium case study (Codrops, "Podium: Building a Website Where Running Becomes Storytelling," Jun 23, 2026) states: *"There's a deliberate slowness to the experience. Elements don't appear instantly; they emerge,"* and describes the brief as one that *"challenged us to design with restraint, to remove rather than add, and to trust the content enough to give it space."* This is precisely the "inevitable, not announced" principle you want. Your lead reference behaves the same way: per Envato Elements' portfolio roundup, *"RoAndCo doesn't rely on flashy animations to get the visitor's attention. Instead, it uses carefully curated visuals and layouts to create an immersive experience."* (Codrops + 2)

2. Premium motion has a measurable grammar. Hover micro-interactions run ~150–300ms; entrance/reveals run ~400–900ms (up to ~1.2s for hero/editorial). Easing is almost always in the "ease-out" family — fast start, long gentle settle — because that reads as an object responding to physics (expensive), whereas `linear` reads mechanical (cheap) and bouncy/overshoot (`back`/spring) easing reads playful and off-register for editorial. The single most-cited "premium" entrance curve is `easeOutExpo = cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)`.

Documented agency-theme grid-image hovers use custom eases such as `cubic-bezier(0.05, 0.2, 0.1, 1)` at ~380ms. (Nic Mulvaney) (ThemeNectar)

3. The canonical grid hover is scale-within-a-crop. The image sits in an `overflow:hidden` wrapper; on hover the `<img>` scales up inside the fixed frame. The *restrained* magnitude is `scale(1.03–1.08)` — heavier `1.15–1.2x` is the mass-market/template default (Divi/Squarespace tutorials use 1.2x) and now reads dated. Trivially CSS-only. (Penpot)

4. The current link underline is a wipe, not a static line. The premium standard animates `transform: scaleX(0→1)` with `transform-origin` swapping edges on enter/exit, or animates a `background-size` gradient underline. Both are pure CSS; the gradient method is multiline-safe. This maps cleanly onto HAUS v4's existing "underline, not color shift" interaction philosophy. (SpinKit) (Dannyguo)

5. Native CSS scroll-driven animation is promising but not yet a safe sole mechanism. Per caniuse (StatCounter, May 2026), `animation-timeline: scroll()` is at **82.58% global support**. Firefox supports it only from **v155** (unsupported through v154); Safari and Safari on iOS from **26.0**; Chromium (Chrome/Edge/Opera) since 115. For a live client-facing portfolio you cannot assume newest browsers, so scroll reveals should use IntersectionObserver (universal), with scroll-driven CSS as at most a progressive enhancement. (caniuse)

6. Squarespace is a real but workable constraint. Custom CSS is available on **all** plans (Design → Custom CSS; note the panel accepts LESS). Code Injection (header/footer) is available on **Core and above** (Squarespace's current 7.1 plan tiers), not the entry Basic plan. Squarespace 7.1 also ships native site-wide animations (Design → Animations: Fade, Scale, Slide, Clip, Flex) — but you cannot target individual blocks and the effects are generic. For a Pentagonagram/RoAndCo-level bar, hand-authored CSS beats the native panel.

Details

Detail layers → technique → Squarespace feasibility

(a) Typography.

- *Fluid type via `clamp()`* — CSS-only, universally supported, production-safe. Highest-leverage typographic upgrade: Archivo Black hero display scales continuously from phone to 2560px with no breakpoint jumps. Use a Perfect Fourth (1.333) ratio for editorial hierarchy.
- *Tracking-on-hover / weight shift* — CSS-only and on-brand; since HAUS v4 already signals interaction through weight, a `letter-spacing` or `font-weight` transition on nav is a natural, restrained micro-interaction.
- *Animated underlines* — CSS-only (see recommended set).
- *Masked line-by-line text reveal* — the award-tier version uses GSAP SplitText, which is NOT cleanly achievable on Squarespace without injecting GSAP + the paid SplitText plugin. **Flag: per-line/per-word masked reveals are out of scope** under a "one lightweight library" budget. A whole-element fade-up is the tasteful, achievable substitute.

- *Letter-by-letter typewriter reveal* — reject as dated.

(b) Spacing/grid rhythm. Pure CSS/layout, zero motion cost. Generous margins (your existing 80px+), asymmetric editorial placement, and border-divider project lists (flat rows with `border-bottom`, not cards) are current-craft and free. Lowest risk, high editorial payoff.

(c) Interaction/hover states.

- Wipe-in link underlines — CSS-only. ✓
- Image hover (scale-in-crop, optional subtle brightness/duotone shift) — CSS-only. ✓
Note: grayscale→color is flagged as "safe/overused" in 2025-26 commentary; for the cream/ink HAUS system a subtle scale + slight brightness reads more bespoke than a grayscale toggle.
- Button/nav states via weight/tracking/underline (not color) — CSS-only, on-brand. ✓
- Cursor followers/trails/custom dot — **reject**. Archetypal "performs taste at the expense of legibility."

(d) Entrance/scroll reveals.

- Single-fire whole-element fade-up — IntersectionObserver (~10 lines) or Squarespace native Fade. ✓ The workhorse.
- Staggered reveals — add incremental `transition-delay` (60-80ms/child); keep subtle. ✓
- Norms — fade-up ~500-800ms, ease-out, `translateY` 16-24px. Distances >40px read as "announced."

(e) Image treatment.

- Hover scale 1.04-1.06 inside `overflow:hidden` — CSS-only. ✓
- Duotone/`filter` transitions — CSS-only; use with restraint. ✓
- `aspect-ratio` framing + lazy fade-up — CSS-only, universal. ✓

The motion timing/easing grammar (the "expensive" defaults)

Fast + eased = expensive; slow + linear or bouncy = cheap/dated. Concrete tokens:

- **Hover (color/underline/weight):** 180-240ms, `ease-out` or `cubic-bezier(0.22, 1, 0.36, 1)`.
- **Image scale hover:** 400-600ms, `cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)` or custom `cubic-bezier(0.05, 0.2, 0.1, 1)`.
- **Entrance fade-up:** 600-800ms, `cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)` (easeOutExpo).
- **Underline wipe:** 300ms, `cubic-bezier(0.76, 0, 0.24, 1)` (easeInOutQuart) for a symmetric wipe, or ease-out for a one-directional draw. (CSS-Tricks)
- **Never:** durations >1.2s on interaction feedback; `linear` on anything organic; `ease-in` alone on entrances (sluggish); overshoot/`back`/spring curves for this editorial register.

Recommendations

Deploy in three stages. Benchmarks that would change the plan are noted.

Stage 1 — Foundation (do first, zero risk, pure CSS)

1. Motion tokens + reduced-motion baseline. Establish CSS custom properties so every later addition is consistent, and gate all motion behind `(prefers-reduced-motion)`. Paste into Design → Custom CSS:

```
css

:root {
  --dur-hover: 200ms;
  --dur-image: 500ms;
  --dur-enter: 700ms;
  --ease-out-expo: cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1);
  --ease-quart: cubic-bezier(0.76, 0, 0.24, 1);
  --ink: #1A1A1A;
}
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  *, *::before, *::after {
    animation-duration: 0.01ms !important;
    animation-iteration-count: 1 !important;
    transition-duration: 0.01ms !important;
    scroll-behavior: auto !important;
  }
}
```

Why premium/current: accessibility is table-stakes for award-tier work; reduced-motion is treated as a parallel design, not an afterthought (per WCAG 2.3.3 and current Codrops practice). Risk: none. [Codrops](#)

2. `clamp()` fluid type scale. Apply to hero/display and section headers (tune to HAUS sizes):

```
css

h1, .hero-display { font-size: clamp(2.75rem, 1.6rem + 5.5vw, 6.5rem); line-height
h2, .section-header { font-size: clamp(1.75rem, 1.2rem + 2.5vw, 3.25rem); }
```

Why: continuous scaling is the current editorial baseline and removes awkward mid-viewport sizes. Risk: low — test line-heights separately for Archivo Black and the Bodoni Moda accent.

Stage 2 — Signature micro-interactions (CSS-only, on-brand)

3. Wipe-in ink underline (multiline-safe gradient method; matches HAUS "underline, not color"):

CSS

```
.content a:not(.btn), nav a {
  text-decoration: none;
  background-image: linear-gradient(var(--ink), var(--ink));
  background-position: 0% 100%;
  background-repeat: no-repeat;
  background-size: 0% 1.5px;
  transition: background-size var(--dur-hover) var(--ease-out-expo);
}

.content a:not(.btn):hover,
.content a:not(.btn):focus-visible,
nav a:hover { background-size: 100% 1.5px; }
```

Why: the wipe-in underline is the current-craft link standard, and the gradient technique survives wrapped lines (pseudo-element/`scaleX` methods break on multiline). Include `:focus-visible` for keyboard users. Risk: low. (Dannyguo)

4. Image scale-within-crop on project tiles:

CSS

```
.project-tile { overflow: hidden; }
.project-tile img {
  transition: transform var(--dur-image) var(--ease-out-expo);
  will-change: transform;
}
.project-tile:hover img { transform: scale(1.045); }
```

Why: the canonical premium grid hover; 1.045 is deliberately restrained (heavier reads templated). Risk: low — inspect the live DOM; you may need to target `.summary-thumbnail-container`, a gallery-section image, or a list-section image element depending on how tiles are built.

5. Refined nav/button hover via weight + tracking (not color):

CSS

```
nav a { transition: letter-spacing var(--dur-hover) var(--ease-out-expo); }
nav a:hover { letter-spacing: 0.02em; }
```

Why: extends the existing HAUS weight-shift language into motion without introducing color. Keep the tracking delta $\leq 0.03\text{em}$ to avoid layout shift. Risk: low.

Stage 3 — Scroll reveal (one small JS snippet, no library)

6. Single-fire fade-up via `IntersectionObserver`. CSS in Custom CSS; JS in Settings → Advanced → Code Injection → Footer. Add class `reveal` to target blocks (via a Code Block

wrapper or section class).

css

```
.reveal { opacity: 0; transform: translateY(20px);
  transition: opacity var(--dur-enter) var(--ease-out-expo),
    transform var(--dur-enter) var(--ease-out-expo); }
.reveal.is-visible { opacity: 1; transform: none; }
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  .reveal { opacity: 1; transform: none; }
}
```

html

```
<script>
document.addEventListener('DOMContentLoaded', function () {
  var els = document.querySelectorAll('.reveal');
  if (!('IntersectionObserver' in window)) {
    els.forEach(function (e) { e.classList.add('is-visible'); }); return;
  }
  var io = new IntersectionObserver(function (entries) {
    entries.forEach(function (entry) {
      if (entry.isIntersecting) {
        entry.target.classList.add('is-visible');
        io.unobserve(entry.target);
      }
    });
  }, { threshold: 0.15, rootMargin: '0px 0px -10% 0px' });
  els.forEach(function (el) { io.observe(el); });
});
</script>
```

Why *IntersectionObserver* over native `animation-timeline`: universal support today, single-fire (no re-animating on scroll-back, which reads cheap), and lighter than any library.

Benchmark to switch to native CSS scroll-driven animation: when `animation-timeline` clears ~95% global support (Firefox shipped it at v155; revisit once that propagates through the install base). Zero-JS alternative: Squarespace's native Fade (Design → Animations) — acceptable but less controllable, and it can't be limited to specific blocks.

The optional / deferred item

Lenis smooth scroll (~3-4KB, one library). Award-tier sites use it in 2026, but as *light native-scroll smoothing* (`lerp: ~0.08`, low inertia) synced to their animation loop — explicitly not scroll-jacking (Lenis wraps native scroll, preserving `position: sticky`, anchor links, and accessibility). Tradeoff: it adds a dependency, can feel wrong on trackpads, and inertia risks the "announced" feeling. **Recommendation: defer.** It doesn't serve legibility. Only add it if, after Stages 1-3, the scroll still feels inert — and if so, use minimal inertia and gate it behind

`prefers-reduced-motion`. This is the one place to stay most conservative given the "inevitable, not announced" mandate.

What to AVOID (assessed for 2026)

- **Cursor followers / trails / custom cursor dots** — dated + trying-too-hard. Reject.
- **Splash / intro loaders** — dated; delay content, announce themselves. Reject.
- **Video backgrounds** — legibility risk, performance cost. Reject (already excluded).
- **Letter-by-letter typewriter reveals** — gimmicky/dated for editorial. Reject.
- **Heavy parallax** — an accessibility/vestibular risk and (per Digital Culture's 2026 retrospective) historically "seen as a mark of an amateurish or out-of-touch designer" when overused; Nielsen Norman Group also documents user "banner blindness" to it. Subtle single-layer depth only, if ever. Reject as a system. `Digital Culture` `Fast Company`
- **Scroll-jacking / forced snap** — now widely viewed as an accessibility failure and INP-killer. Reject.
- **Marquee / ticker text** — reads as trend-chasing; only defensible as a deliberate brutalist statement, which is off-register for HAUS. Reject.
- **Grayscale-everything toggle** — not wrong, but "safe/overused"; prefer a subtler brightness/duotone treatment consistent with the cream/ink palette.

Caveats

- **Squarespace selectors are not guaranteed stable.** Squarespace can change generated class names in platform updates; injected CSS/JS lives outside official support and may need maintenance. Test every snippet against the live DOM — the `.project-tile`/image selectors above are illustrative; inspect the actual gallery/summary/list markup.
- **Code Injection requires Core plan or above.** Pure Custom CSS (Stages 1-2) works on all plans; the Stage 3 reveal snippet needs Core+.
- **Browser-support numbers are time-sensitive.** `animation-timeline` (~82.58% global mid-2026; Firefox from v155, Safari/iOS from 26) will keep rising — re-check caniuse before adopting native scroll-driven animation as a sole mechanism.
- **The named studios don't publish specs.** RoAndCo, Pentagram, Anagrama, and Wolff Olins do not publish CSS/timing values; the specific numbers here are triangulated from Codrops developer case studies, easings references (`easeOutExpo = cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)`), and agency-theme conventions — the strongest available sourced authorities. `Nic Mulvaney`
- **Performance discipline:** animate only `transform`/`opacity`/`filter`; never animate layout properties (width/height/margin). Test INP/Core Web Vitals after each stage. `GitHub`